

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Spanish-American War and the Question of Empire, 1898

US.22 — Compare and contrast the arguments of imperialists and non-imperialists of the period.

US.23 — Describe the effects of American imperialism, including: • Spanish-American War • Annexation of Hawaii • Panama Canal • Philippine Insurrection • Access to Cuba • Roosevelt Corollary

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the three documents below. Then write a well-organized essay that constructs an argument addressing the following question: Did the Spanish-American War represent a turning point in American foreign policy, or was it the inevitable product of forces already at work in American society and politics? Your essay must: — Apply SOAPS analysis (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Significance) to at least two of the three documents — Use evidence from all three documents — Incorporate outside knowledge of the period — Construct a clear, defensible argument

The sources

Document 1

President William McKinley, War Message to Congress, April 11, 1898 — Bryan, William Jennings, ed., *Republic or Empire* (1899), public domain, public domain

“The present condition of affairs in Cuba is a constant menace to our peace and entails upon this Government an enormous expense. With such a conflict waged for years in an island so near our border and with which our people have such trade and business relations; when the lives and liberty of our citizens are in constant danger and their property destroyed and themselves ruined; where our trading vessels are liable to seizure and are seized at our very door by warships of a foreign nation — the expedient of enforcing American interests will justify forceful intervention.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 1

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document 2

Teller Amendment, April 20, 1898, Bryan, William Jennings, ed., Republic or Empire (1899), public domain — public domain

“Resolved by the Senate and House of Representatives... That the United States hereby disclaims any disposition or intention to exercise sovereignty, jurisdiction, or control over said Island except for the pacification thereof, and asserts its determination, when that is accomplished, to leave the government and control of the Island to its people.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 2

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

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hear it?

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What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document 3

Platt Amendment, 1901, Statutes at Large of the United States — public domain

“The government of Cuba consents that the United States may exercise the right to intervene for the preservation of Cuban independence, the maintenance of a government adequate for protecting life, property, and individual liberty, and for discharging the obligations with respect to Cuba imposed by the Treaty of Paris on the United States... Cuba will sell or lease to the United States lands necessary for coaling or naval stations at certain specified points to be agreed upon with the President of the United States.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 3

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

DOCUMENT 3 Platt Amendment, 1901, Statutes at Large of the United States — public domain: "The government of Cuba consents that the United States may exercise the right to intervene for the preservation of Cuban independence, the maintenance of a government adequate for protecting life, property, and individual liberty, and for discharging the obligations with respect to Cuba imposed by the Treaty of Paris on the United States... Cuba will sell or lease to the United States lands necessary for coaling or naval stations at certain specified points to be agreed upon with the President of the United States."

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document 1		
Document 2		
Document 3		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Complex thesis addressing both 'turning point' and 'inevitable product' dimensions. SOAPS analysis of at least two documents accurately and specifically. Cross-document synthesis (Teller → Platt contradiction). Extensive outside knowledge. Well-organized argumentative essay.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. SOAPS applied to at least two documents accurately. Good outside knowledge. Addresses the Teller/Platt contradiction but may not fully develop the 'turning point vs. inevitable' framework.
4	Proficient. Clear thesis. Uses all three documents as evidence. SOAPS applied to at least two documents with reasonable accuracy. Some outside knowledge. Coherent argument.
3	Adequate. Thesis present but simple. Uses two or more documents. Some SOAPS elements. Limited outside knowledge. Some organizational issues.
2	Developing. Weak or no thesis. Uses one or two documents without SOAPS. Little outside knowledge. Descriptive rather than argumentative.
1	Beginning. No thesis. Minimal document use. No SOAPS. No outside knowledge.
0	No response or completely off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: — Doc 1: McKinley's economic/commercial framing; distinguish from humanitarian yellow-press justification; note 'enforcing American interests' as the operative phrase. — Doc 2: Teller's explicit anti-annexation intent; note its unanimous passage alongside the war authorization; significance = set up later contradiction with Platt. — Doc 3: Platt's intervention rights and naval basing provisions; note this was imposed as a condition of U.S. military withdrawal; Cuba had no real choice; significance = established protectorate in all but name. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Mahan's influence; De Lôme Letter; USS Maine (Feb. 15, 1898); Commodore Dewey Manila Bay (May 1, 1898); Battle of San Juan Hill; Treaty of Paris (1898); Philippine acquisition; Teller-to-Platt contradiction; Guantanamo Bay lease (still in force); Cuba as protectorate 1901–1934.

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.